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Senate of Virginia Floor Session, Wednesday, January 14, 2026

Date	Wednesday, January 14, 2026
Place	Senate of Virginia, Senate Chamber, State Capitol, Richmond
Length	8h 44m (video)

- Official floor video (Senate of Virginia, YouTube): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=27tbaTagZQU
- LIS Senate minutes: https://lis.virginia.gov/session-details/20261/minutes-list/S

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[00:00:34] This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

[00:01:38] Chamber.

[00:01:39] This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

[00:04:43] Chamber.

[00:05:20] Did you know that you can watch the Senate live on YouTube?

[00:05:47] Visit the channel by browsing to youtube.com forward slash at symbol Senate of Virginia. That's youtube.com forward slash at Senate of Virginia.

[00:06:06] Virginia.

[00:07:02] Richmond, Virginia.

[00:08:05] Chamber.

[00:08:53] This is the Senate of Virginia.

[00:10:07] Richmond, Virginia.

[00:10:58] Chamber.

[00:11:10] Did you know that you can watch the Senate live on YouTube?

[00:12:14] Visit the channel by browsing to youtube.com forward slash at symbol Senate of Virginia. That's youtube.com forward slash at Senate of Virginia.

[00:12:38] This is the Senate of Virginia.

[00:13:29] Richmond, Virginia.

[00:14:31] Chamber.

[00:16:08] This is the Senate of Virginia.

[00:16:34] Richmond, Virginia.

[00:17:36] Chamber.

[00:17:37] Do you know that you can watch the Senate live on YouTube?

[00:18:40] Visit the channel by browsing to youtube.com forward slash at symbol Senate of Virginia. That's youtube.com forward slash at Senate of Virginia.

[00:19:05] Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

[00:20:51] Chamber, this is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

[00:23:02] Chamber, do you know that you can watch the Senate live on YouTube?

[00:25:06] Visit the channel by browsing to youtube.com forward slash at symbol Senate of Virginia. That's youtube.com forward slash at Senate of Virginia.

[00:26:21] Virginia. Richmond, Virginia.

[00:27:24] Chamber.

[00:29:25] This is the Senate of Virginia. Richmond, Virginia.

[00:30:17] Chamber.

[00:30:48] You know that you can watch the Senate live on YouTube?

[00:31:33] Visit the channel by browsing to youtube.com forward slash at symbol Senate of Virginia. That's youtube.com forward slash at Senate of Virginia.

[00:31:58] Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

[00:34:20] This is the Senate of Virginia, Richmond, Virginia.

[00:36:01] Chamber, did you know that you can watch the Senate live on YouTube?

[00:38:00] Visit the channel by browsing to youtube.com forward slash at symbol Senate of Virginia. That's youtube.com forward slash at Senate of Virginia.

[00:38:12] Senate will come to order. Senators will please take their seats.

[00:41:54] Those persons not entitled to the privileges of the floor will please retire to the gallery. Senators and all in attendance, if you are able, please rise.

[00:42:20] We will stand for a moment of silent prayer.

[00:42:33] Please remain standing. We will be led in the Pledge of Allegiance to the flag of the United States of America by Andrew Horton, Assistant Coordinator of Committee Operations in the Senate Clerk's Office.

[00:42:57] I pledge allegiance to the flag of the United States of America and to the republic for which it stands, one nation, under God, indivisible, with liberty and justice for all. Clerk will call the roll. All those present, please vote aye.

[00:43:27] Clerk will close the roll.

[00:43:44] You have a quorum, Madam President. Senate journaled for Friday, October 31st, 2025.

[00:44:11] Senator Obenshain, the senator from Rockingham, moves that the reading of the journal be waived. All those in favor of waiving the reading of the journal will record their votes. Aye. Those opposed, no. Are the senators ready to vote? Have all the senators voted?

[00:44:29] Does any senator desire to change their vote? Clerk will close the roll. Ayes 36, no is 4.

[00:44:50] - Ayes 36, noes four. The reading of the journal is waived. Chair now calls on. - Soroville. - Senator Soroville.

[00:45:06] - Thank you, Madam President. Madam President, good morning, or good afternoon. - Good afternoon, the Senator from Eastern Fairfax County. - Thank you, and I move the Senate to now adjourn sine die. - Sine die. - As many as are in favor.

[00:45:21] - Sine die. - I see we're picking up where we left off. As many as are in favor of the motion to adjourn sine die. will say aye. Those opposed, no. The ayes have it. The motion is agreed to. The Senate is adjourned.

[00:45:38] Signee die. The Senate will again come to order. The Senators will again please take their seats,

[00:47:20] and those persons not entitled to the privileges of the floor will retire to the gallery. We've done this once before, just now, and it's not deja vu. The Senators in all in attendance, again please stand if you are able and we will be led in prayer this time it will be by rabbi dovid asher of keneseth beth israel of richmond following the prayer if everyone will please

[00:47:57] remain standing and we will be led in the pledge of allegiance to the flag of the united states of america by ansel eastman of chesterfield times for the jewish community i deeply deeply appreciate this honor to be with you today to start this year's session let us pray to our

[00:48:26] creator we cry out to god from this august historic seat of power in a united humility to lower ourselves to kneel our own might and to bring to heal our own premonitions before you god our maker we are unified here in this act of bowing bowing our heads submitting to the almighty that we are committed in service to the greater good of this commonwealth these united states and

[00:49:02] to his world overall we beseech that this 165th assembly be defined not by pettiness but by a loftiness that our officials here both the incumbents and the newly elected seek popularity not cheaply among the masses but rather a popularity in the heavens with resolve to march towards the justice of you, God, and not towards an artificial meager false substitute.

[00:49:31] To the Almighty we say that we here are committed to a togetherness in spite of difference, because we know, above all, your will is for tolerance, for love, and for peace among your loyal subjects.

On this first day now, we commit these next 61 days to be faithful to the words of of the prophet Isaiah, Yeshayahu Hanavi, who declared, "Lo machshavosei machshavoseichem," that God's calculations are not mankind's, that only God has infinite wisdom, and man

[00:50:09] ought to recognize his limited capacity. No opinion is omnipotent beyond the Almighty's, and that, consequentially, that means we seek not conformity, but sincerity. Lastly, God, please have mercy on our brethren in Mississippi, whose largest synagogue, tragically, had their sanctuary burned to the ground this past week by an evil hatred that has plagued our American towns and cities for far too long.

[00:50:40] May this animus be washed away and to bigotry let there be no sanction. Let us rebuild honor, decency, and a noble abidance in your name. Let us have a joyful freedom ring out on our streets and reign supreme as children's fears and the fears of all minorities and all citizens be dispelled by a zealous love and embrace of the divine word. May you God bless the Senate and all our elected officials and government workers with health, happiness, and a steadfast resolve to pursue righteousness for the advancement

[00:51:20] of a more inspired, more redemptive, and more worthy Commonwealth of Virginia. Let us say Amen. A Pledge of Allegiance to the flag of the United States of America and to the Republic for which it stands, one nation, under God, indivisible, with liberty and justice for all.

[00:51:58] Clark will again please call the roll. All those present, vote aye. Clark will close the roll.

[00:52:28] You have a quorum, Madam President. The Senate is operating under the rules of the Senate, adopted at the commencement of the 2024 session.

[00:52:45] The clerk will report any communications. November the 12th, 2025. Senator L. Louise Lucas, President Pro Tempori, Senate of Virginia.

[00:53:02] Post Office Box 396, Richmond, Virginia, 23218. Dear Madam President Pro Temporee, I write to inform you that I intend to resign my seat representing Senate District 15, effective noon, January 17, 2026, or immediately upon taking my oath of office as the 43rd Lieutenant Governor of Virginia.

[00:53:26] The past six years of serving as the state senator for the constituents of Richmond City and Chesterfield County have been an incredible honor. I look forward to continuing to work with you and my colleagues in both Virginia Senate and the House of Delegates in my new role.

[00:53:44] Sincerely yours, Ghazala F. Hashmi, Ph.D., Chair, Senate Education and Health Committee, Member of Virginia Senate.

[00:53:53] January 7, 2026, Senator L. Louise Lucas, President Pro Temporee, Senate of Virginia, Post Office Box 396, Richmond 23218.

[00:54:30] Dear Madam President pro tempore, please accept this email as my formal notification that I will resign my seat representing the 39th District in the Senate of Virginia, effective Wednesday, February the 18th, 2026 at 12 noon. I am leaving to assume the role of Senior Advisor at the Virginia Cannabis Control Authority in the administration of Governor-elect Spanberger.

[00:54:56] It has been my honor to serve with you in the Senate for the last 14 years, and I wish you the best of luck in moving Virginia forward. Thank you for your service and leadership.

[00:55:07] Sincerely yours, Adam Eben, member of Senator Virginia.

[00:55:48] - For now recognizes the Senator from Hampton. Senator Locke, for the purpose of taking up a resolution. - Thank you, Madam President. Madam President, I move that the rules be suspended, the Committee on Rules be discharged from further consideration of the resolution, the readings of the title and the engrossment be waived, and SR3 be taken up for immediate consideration?

[00:56:11] - Question is, shall the rules be suspended, the Committee on Rules be discharged from further consideration of the resolution, the readings of the title and the engrossment be waived, and Senate Resolution number three be taken up for immediate consideration?

[00:56:34] All in favor of the motion, we'll record their votes. Aye, those opposed, no. Are the Senators ready to vote? Have all the Senators voted? Does any Senator desire to change their vote? The Clerk will close the roll.

[00:56:51] Ayes 40, noes 0. Ayes 40, noes 0. The rules are suspended to take up the resolution for immediate consideration. The Clerk will report the resolution.

[00:57:07] Senate Resolution 3, Senate Operating Resolution. Terrigan recognizes the Senator from Hampton. Senator Locke. Thank you, Madam President.

[00:57:22] the resolution be agreed to and speaking to the resolution the senator may continue madam president the resolution is as stated the operating resolution which speaks to per diem and salaries for the 2020 succession again i move that the resolution be agreed to the question is shall resolution number three be agreed to all in favor of agreeing to the resolution will record their votes aye those opposed no are the senators ready to vote of all the senators voted does any senator

[00:57:52] desire to change their vote. Clerk will close the roll. Ayes 40, no 0. Ayes 40, no 0. The resolution is agreed to. The senator from eastern Fairfax County, Senator Surivelle, who has duly fled,

[00:58:25] will advise the House of Delegates that the Senate is duly organized and ready to proceed to business. Normally at this time we would have waited for the senator to return, but I think we should proceed to business until he does that. So we have arrived at the time then in our morning hour when we will hear who our wonderful visitors in the gallery are. And the procedure is that

[00:59:02] the senator will rise and tell us who you are. And if you hold your applause until after I have recognized you, then we will applaud you together. And so with that, I do call on Senator Mulcahy, a senator from Mecklenburg County. Off to a good start here. Thank you, Madam President. I rise for an introduction. Senator May Sayon. Would our good rabbi rise to be introduced and your beautiful

[00:59:42] bride i believe is with you um rabbi david asher grew up in allentown pennsylvania with ncsy in his synagogue as the early molder of his community service he attended the jewish educational center for high school in elizabeth new jersey he was the regional president of the new jersey ncsy asher then went to israel to study the torah at i'm sorry i cannot pronounce that but it's it's a lovely four-letter word he went on to do a lot of studying at a lot of universities

[01:00:19] and places that I also cannot I cannot pronounce he got a BS in psychology with a minor in business masters in mental health counseling and a masters masters in mental health counseling and I thought I saw something else but now I I can't find it. His beautiful bride is Eliza, is that correct? And she is originally from Miami Beach, Florida. I was just there catching a cruise and I'm glad you got out. Eliza is an interior

[01:00:57] designer and an artist with degrees from places I can't pronounce, but one of them was the Fashion Institute of Technology in New York City. They have four adorable children. They got some pretty tough names too um but i'm sure they're very lovely as you two are together they love to host and greet the richmond community um please welcome our rabbi and his beautiful bride to the general assembly to the senate and we're so happy to have you and your wonderful prayer and we do pray for

[01:01:32] israel every day thank you so much can we give them a warm oh well the lovely lieutenant governor is gonna gonna say some warm words for you as well i'm sure she'll do better than i did don't think so as you've seen rabbi we're a bit rusty and that's the normal routine here until we get back into the ways that we are and we're just so glad to have you once again and we're glad that your wife lies with you and you know you've been my rabbi whenever i've ever had questions about the Bible that didn't make any sense and you've read it to me in Hebrew and broken it down and we've understood that certain words in Hebrew don't mean

[01:02:12] the same in English and so then the meaning becomes clear I'm so glad that I've had you to help me through and thank you for your prayer for us and it thank you thank you ma'am for allowing him to serve our great community here in Richmond and elsewhere people who serve in capacity of faith leaders they give so much so much and sometimes unfortunately family suffers so thank you thank you for being here

[01:02:40] senators let us give them the warm welcome of their senate chair calls on the senator from orange senator reeves thank you madam president i rise for an introduction the senator has the floor madam president in the gallery today somebody that's going to be very important to a lot of us as we move forward with this session having just come out of being sick is dr trice gravid dr gravid

[01:03:18] is a constituent of mine from Culpeper, and he's our doc of the day today, and he volunteers annually with the General Assembly to ensure all of us stay healthy and fit to conduct our work, Senator Stanley. Dr. Gravatt, Senator Stanley needs to probably see you today, by the way.

[01:03:37] He's a part of the Medical Society of Virginia, the Virginia Academy of Family Practitioners, and is past president of the Virginia Association of Free Clinics. Dr. Gravitt is practicing faculty at UVA, works to recruit and train rural physicians.

[01:03:52] I'm always honored to have such a dedicated, civically-minded active constituents like Dr. Gravitt, and I would ask Madam President that you would give him the warm welcome of the Senate. - Doctor, please rise. Thank you. Thank you for all that you've done for us and you continue to do, and for putting up with us.

[01:04:12] You know, we can be a crabbity bunch of folks. Thank you for serving us and serving us so very well and your community as well all these years. Thank you. We don't have enough folks in the medical field and we need more. Thank you. Often you meet us when we're not at our best and that's why we're crabbit.

[01:04:31] But you see through that and you understand it's because we're ill and we want to be well. So thank you very much. Senators, let us give him the warm welcome of his Senate.

[01:04:52] Senator from Hanover, Senator McDougall. Senator McDougall: Thank you, Madam President. - Madam President, I rise for introduction. - The Senator has the floor. - Madam President, we have with us in the gallery a gentleman that you know very well, your husband Terry.

[01:05:08] He has been with you for-- - Yes. - For a long time, but particularly by your side over the last number of months as you've traversed the state. And we would ask that you offer him the warm welcome of the Senate and your thanks for enduring the trials and tribulations which have come with that effort of running for office.

[01:05:33] - Thank you, Senator, and thank you, husband. We have been through a lot together. We both, well, you had hair, and I was not gray, and so we were so very young when we met.

[01:05:49] What is it, 39 years now? And you've put up with a lot, but you've been my rock, and could not have done it without you, and our wonderful children, thank you. Senators, please let us give him the warm welcome of his Senate.

[01:06:02] Senator Cerroville, having returned from the communication of the House,

[01:06:33] we will be at ease until the Senate having been notified by the House

[01:47:21] and being procedural, the resolution will be taken up for immediate consideration, which was previously delivered by delegates from Alexandria, Delegate Herring. The clerk will please report the resolution.

[01:47:39] House Joint Resolution number 38, notifying the governor of organization, resolved by the House of Delegates, the Senate concurring that a committee be appointed composed of six on the part of the House of Delegates and four on the part of the Senate to notify the governor that the General Assembly is duly organized and ready to receive any communication he may desire to make.

[01:48:01] The question is, shall the resolution be agreed to? All in favor of agreeing to the resolution, we'll say aye. Those opposed, no. The ayes have it.

[01:48:18] The resolution is agreed to. The senator from Eastern Fairfax County, Senator Surivel, will please inform the House of Delegates of the action of the Senate.

[01:48:40] Senators, pursuant to the foregoing resolution, the chair now appoints senator from Portsmouth, Senator Lucas.

[01:49:12] the senator from Hampton, Senator Locke, the senator from eastern Fairfax County, Senator Suravelle, and the senator from Hanover, Senator McDougall, as the committee on the part of the Senate, together with the members of the House to inform the governor that the General Assembly is duly organized and ready to receive any communication he may desire to make.

[01:49:44] The Senate will be at ease until the committee returns from the Governor's office.

[01:49:51] President at Arms, please receive it.

[02:06:00] Thank you, Madam President. H.J.R. 29 is providing for certain joint assembly in establishing schedules for the conduct of business coming before the 2026 regular session for the pre-finding period of the 2027 regular session and request the concurrence of the Senate.

[02:06:30] Thank you, Madam President. Thank the delegate chair recognizes the senator from chair recognizes Adam clerk please establishing a schedule for the conduct of business coming before the 2026 regular session of the General Assembly of Virginia and providing for legislative continuity between the 2026 and 2027 regular sessions of the

[02:07:09] General Assembly the HJR is referred to the committee on rules chair recognizes now the senator from Portsmouth. Senator Lucas.

[02:07:28] - I'm sorry. - The senator from Portsmouth. Senator Lucas. - Senator from Portsmouth. - Page 10. - Yeah, page 10. - You're exactly right.

[02:07:51] - Change one to change two. Chair now recognizes the senator from Hampton. Senator Locke. - Thank you, Madam President. Madam President, I move that the rules be suspended. The Committee on Rules be discharged from further consideration. resolution the reading of the title be waived in hdr 29 be taken up for immediate consideration the question is shall the rules be suspended the committee on rules be discharged from further consideration of the resolution the readings of the title waived and house joint resolution 29 be taken up for immediate consideration all in favor of the motion will record their votes aye

[02:08:30] those opposed nor are the senators ready to vote have all the senators voted does any senator desire to change their vote the clerk will close the roll i was 39 no zero eyes 39 no zero the rules are suspended to take up the resolution for immediate consideration now chair recognizes the senator from portsmouth madam president pro temporee

[02:09:26] madam president the committee appointed to inform the governor of the organization of the general assembly wishes to report that they have performed the duties assigned to them and that the governor would be pleased to address a joint assembly of the legislature.

[02:09:54] I thank the senator. Karen now recognizes the senator from Hampton.

[02:10:23] Senator Locke. Madam President, I move that SJR 20, that House Joint Resolution 29 be agreed to and speaking to that.

[02:10:45] The senator may continue. House Joint Resolution 29 is the organizational operational resolution and I would point to one change in this resolution to everybody's attention as rule 25 lines 185 through 187 which clarifies that um when joint subcommittees uh and study res commissions are formed that the rules that govern those uh commissions and study commissions uh will be determined by the chamber

[02:11:20] of the chairman of that Joint Study Commission. And that's the one change to this resolution. And with that explanation, Madam President, I move that the resolution be agreed to. The question is, shall the resolution be agreed to? All in favor of agreeing to the resolution will record their votes. Aye. Those opposed, no. Are the senators ready to vote?

[02:11:49] Have all the senators voted? Does any senator desire to change their vote? the clerk will close the roll as 39 no zero eyes 39 no zero the resolution is agreed to house joint resolution 30 establishing a schedule for the conduct of business for the pre-filing period of the 2027 regular session of the general assembly of virginia this resolution has been referred to the committee on rules chair again recognizes the senator from hampton senator lock

[02:12:26] madam president i move that the rules be suspended the committee on rules be discharged and further consideration of the resolution the readings of the title be waived and hdr 30 be taken up for immediate consideration the question is shall the rules be suspended the committee on rules be discharged from further consideration of the resolution the readings of the title be waived and house joint

resolution 30 be taken up for immediate consideration all in favor of the motion will record their votes aye those opposed no are the senators ready to vote of all the

[02:13:01] senators voted does any senator desire to change their vote the clerk will close the roll eyes 40 no zero eyes 40 no zero the resolution is taken up for immediate consideration the rules are suspended again senator locke the senator from hampton thank you madam president uh i move that

[02:13:35] the resolution be agreed to and speaking to the resolution the senator may say on um house joint resolution 30 uh establishes the pre-file period for the 2027 session beginning on november 30 2026 and with that explanation i move that the resolution be agreed to question is shall the resolution be agreed to all in favor of agreeing to the resolution will record their votes aye

[02:14:13] those opposed no are the senators ready to vote of all the senators voted does any senator desire to change their vote. Clerk will close the roll. Eyes 39, no 0. Eyes 39, no 0. The resolution is agreed to. The senator from Hampton, Senator Locke, will inform the House of Delegates of the action

[02:14:37] of the Senate. Resolutions, petitions, and bills are now in order. Senator Marsden, chair then

[02:15:12] recognizes the senator from eastern Fairfax County. Senator Surivel. Madam President, this is the time for anyone else who has any first day bills which are VRS bills or legislation requesting a study to be turned in or I'm sorry if you have one you have not yet introduced it you need to have it at the clerk's desk by five o'clock and that's for all bills that have to do with VRS or legislation requesting a study so the clerk needs to be advised you have to have it to them by five

[02:15:41] okay thanks senator wishes to continue having waiting on the senator to return the senate will

[02:16:01] be temporarily at ease. Chair recognizes Senator Surrillville. The Senator from Eastern Fairfax

[02:51:44] County. Thank you, Madam President. Madam President, I'm going to move that we stand in recess until 2.30. I think the Senate Republican caucus would like to have a conversation. So I think 25 minutes should be sufficient. We can come back. We have one more item of business we need to take up after that. And then we hope to recess so the P&E committee can start working. That's the motion.

[02:52:09] The Senator from Charlottesville, Senator Dietz. Without objection, the Senate stands at recess for 25 minutes.

[03:06:27] Chair now recognizes the Senator from Hampton, Senator Locke, for the purpose of presenting the Committee Nominations Report.

[03:39:28] Thank you, Madam President. Madam President, I request that the Committee Nominations Report on the Senate Standing Committees be taken up. The clerk will read said report. 26 Senate Standing Committees, Agriculture, Conservation, and Natural Resources, Senators Marsden, Chair, Obenshain, Stewart, Stanley, Suterlein, Hackworth, Williams-Graves, Perry, Prakarski, French, Salim, Mulcahy, Rome, Senevason, and Vacancy.

[03:40:06] Sports of Justice, Surabelle Chair, Obenshain, McDougal, Deeds, Stewart, Stanley, Boisco, Peek, Bagley, Bagby, and Aird, Carol Foy, Perry, Saleem, Favola, and Sturtevant.

[03:40:25] Education and Health. Favola, Chair, Lucas, Locke, Suterlein, Peek, Pillian, Boisco, Bagby, Head, Aird, Van Valkenburg, Durant, Prakarski, Craig, and Perry.

[03:40:43] Finance and Appropriations. Lucas, Chair, Deeds, Locke, Marston, Eben, McDougal, Obenshain, Stewart, Reeves, Favola, Saravelle, McPike, Boisco, Pillian, and Rouse.

[03:41:01] Privileges and elections: Rouse, Chair, Deeds, Eben, Hackworth, Deestuff, Van Valkenburg, Carol Foy, Durant, Perry, Diggs, Salim, Molkai, Senevisen, Cyphers, and Jordan.

[03:41:18] Rehabilitation and Social Services: Van Valkenburg, Chair, McDougal, Reeves, Favola, surveil d step head jordan williams graves carol boy finch salim peak rome and a vacancy transportation bagby chair marsden d step suderland boys co hackworth sturdivant aired rome digs Bukarski, Molka, Senevacen, Cyphers, and a vacancy.

[03:41:58] Rules: Locke, Chair, Lucas, Deeds, Marston, Favola, Eben, McPike, Cervell, Rouse, Bagby, McDougall, Stewart, Killian, Craig, and a vacancy.

[03:42:13] The Chair again recognizes the Senator from Hampton. Madam President, I move that the committee nominations report be adopted. The question is, shall the report be adopted?

[03:42:32] all in favor of adoption of the report will record their votes aye those opposed no the senators ready to vote have all the senators voted does any senator desire to change their vote the clerk will close the roll ayes 39 no zero ayes 39 no zero the committee nominations report

[03:43:08] is adopted my favorite expression pray tell is there any other business to come before the senate to recognize is senator cerebell the senator from eastern fairfax county thank you madam president i rise for an announcement and a motion the senator may continue first of all man president there's this uh composite seating chart going around with a bunch of signatures on i'm not sure where it's supposed to go but it's now fully signed so whoever wanted this it'll be sitting on

[03:43:43] my desk um second thing matter president i'm going to move that we recess until 4 30. reason for that is the house of delegates is out until four and they have to debate their four amendments before they can communicate them to us and 90 minutes i hope will give our privileges and elections committee sufficient time to meet and take up the three amendments that are starting over here so we can conclude debate and vote on those so that when the house amendments come over we can revote the same three cognates or whatever you call them quickly without debate and then do the fourth amendment we haven't seen before afterwards and that way we can

[03:44:23] probably save ourselves about an hour and a half or two hours of work later tonight when I think most of us are probably doing something else than sitting in committee so that's the plan and I would move that we recess till 4:30 question is shall the Senate stand in recess until 4:30 p.m. today all in favor of the motion will say aye those opposed no the ayes have it the motion is to the Senate stands in recess until 4:30 p.m. at which time it will convene in

[03:45:00] the Senate chamber to proceed to the House of Delegates to receive the State of the Commonwealth Address by the Governor. Correction 4:30 p.m. at which time it will convene in the Senate chamber to proceed to the House of

[03:45:27] Delegates to receive. Don't worry I'll be gone soon. At which time the Senate

[03:45:51] stands in recess until 4 30 p.m. all right the committee on privileges and elections the committee

[03:46:08] on privileges and elections will meet 30 minutes after recess in senate room b in the gab senator

[06:13:10] sorrowville senator from eastern fairfax county good evening madam president good evening uh madam president i've moved to wave reading of the communication of the house of delegates are we there yet oh supplemental calendar sorry i don't think i'd do anything on that the clerk will call the calendar joint resolution i'm getting six directions wait a minute supplemental calendar number one senate resolution one proposing an amendment to the constitution of virginia by

[06:13:47] adding an art in article one a section numbered 11a relating to fundamental right to reproductive freedom senate joint resolution two proposing an amendment to section one of article two of the constitution of virginia relating qualifications of voters and the right to vote persons not entitled to vote Senate Joint Resolution 3 proposing an amendment to section 15 - a of article 1 of the Constitution of Virginia relating to marriage between two adult persons repeal of same-sex marriage prohibition affirmative right

[06:14:26] to marry senator Sorovell the senator from Eastern Fairfax County president now I move to waive the reading of communication from the House of delegates the question is shall the reading of the communication from the House delegates be waived all in favor of waiving the reading will record their votes aye those opposed no are the senators ready to vote have all the

[06:15:03] senators voted does any senator desire to change their vote the clerk will close the roll ice 37 knows to the reading of the communication from the House of

[06:15:17] delegates is waived tell Jonathan to wait

[06:16:42] Clark will read any announcements on the desk today Wednesday January 14 2026 the committee on privileges and elections will meet immediately upon recess in the next five minutes in Senate room B in the GAB privileges and

[06:17:04] elections immediately upon recess Senate room B GAB again senator Thank you, Madam President. Madam President, I move that we stand in recess until 6:30 when it's time for us to go be with the guy on the third floor.

[06:17:39] Without objection, the Senate now stands in recess until 6:30 at which time it will reconvene in the Senate chamber to proceed to the House of Delegates to receive the State of the Commonwealth Address by the Governor.

[06:37:11] Again, those persons not entitled to the privileges of the floor will please retire to the gallery.

[07:22:11] The hour having arrived for the Joint Assembly to receive the governor, the senators will rise and proceed to the hall of the House of Delegates accompanied by the President of the Senate and the Clerk of the Senate.

[07:22:28] Upon adjournment of the Joint Assembly, the senators will please return to the Senate chamber.

[07:22:35] The House will come to order.

[07:26:39] Sergeant in Arms. Mr. Speaker, the Senate of Virginia. The members of the House will rise and receive the Senate of Virginia.

[07:27:14] The Joint Assembly will come to order.

[07:27:56] The clerk of the Senate will call the roll of the Senate. Senator Aird.

[07:28:13] Senator Aird. Senator Bagby. Senator Boisco. Senator Carol Foy. Senator Cyphers. Senator Craig. Senator Deeds.

[07:28:30] Senator Deesteph. Senator Diggs. Senator Durant. Senator Eben. Senator Favola. Senator French, Senator Hackworth, Senator Hashmi, Senator Head, Senator Jordan, Senator Jordan, Senator Locke, Senator Lucas, Senator Marsden, Senator McDougall, Senator McPike,

[07:29:01] Senator Mulcahy, Senator Obenshain, Senator Peake, Senator Pekarski, Senator Perry, Senator Pileon, Senator Reeves, Senator Rome, Senator Rouse, Senator Salim, Senator Senevasin, Senator

[07:29:26] Stanley, Senator Stanley. Anybody seen Senator Stanley? Senator Stewart, Senator Sturdivant, Senator Suterlund, Senator Cerevelle, Senator Van Valkenburg, Senator Williams Graves. You have a quorum, Mr. President. The members of the House will indicate their presence on the electronic

[07:29:55] voting board. Clerk will close the roll. Mr. President, a quorum is present. The clerk will report a resolution. Resolution of the joint assembly notifying the governor of organization resolve that the president of the joint assembly appoint a committee of 10 composed of six delegates and four senators to notify the governor that the joint assembly is duly organized and would be pleased to receive him in any communication he may desire to make. As many as favor adoption of the

[07:30:32] resolution will say aye. Those opposed will say no. The resolution is agreed to. The clerk will announce the committee to notify the governor that the General Assembly is ready to receive him and hear any remarks he wishes to make. Mr. President appoints the following members to notify the governor to escort him to the Joint Assembly. Delegates Herring, Torian, Hayes, Tran, Kilgore, and Wyatt, as well as Senators Lucas, Locke, Cerevelle, and McDougal. The Joint

[07:31:05] Assembly will be at ease. Sergeant at Arms. Mr. President, entering from the gallery,

[07:37:24] the First Lady of the Commonwealth and her party. - The Joint Assembly will receive the First Lady of the Commonwealth and her party.

[07:37:47] - Mr. President, the Governor's Cabinet and other Executive Branch officials. - The General Assembly will receive the Governor's Cabinet

[07:38:01] and other Executive Branch officials.

[07:38:37] - Mr. President, the Chairman and Commissioners of the State Corporation Commission.

[07:38:57] - The Joint Assembly will receive the Chairman and Commissioners of the State Corporation Commission. - Mr. President, the Chief Justice and Justices of the Supreme Court.

[07:39:19] - The Joint Assembly will receive the Chief Justice and Justices of the Supreme Court.

[07:39:46] - Mr. President, the Attorney General of Virginia. - The Joint Assembly and guests will please be seated.

[07:40:21] The Joint Assembly will be at ease.

[07:44:56] The House will come to order, Sergeant-at-Arms. - Mr. President, His Excellency, the Governor of the Commonwealth of Virginia. - The members will receive the Governor

[07:45:05] of the Commonwealth of Virginia.

[07:47:22] Joint Assembly and guests, please be seated.

[07:47:44] As Speaker of the House of Delegates and President of the Joint Assembly, It is my pleasure to present to you His Excellency, the Governor of the Commonwealth of Virginia, the Honorable Glenn Youngkin.

[07:48:10] Thank you all very much.

[07:48:34] What an honor it is to be with all of you this evening. Mr. Speaker, Lieutenant Governor Earl Sears, Madam President, Attorney General Meares, Members of the General Assembly, Chief Justice of the Supreme Court, Powell, and congratulations.

[07:48:58] Justices of the Virginia Supreme Court and judges of the State Corporation Commission are clerks, members of my cabinet, and my fellow Virginians, it's an honor to join you once again in Mr.

[07:49:16] Jefferson's Capitol for my report on the state of our beloved Commonwealth. The Commonwealth is soaring. The Commonwealth is alive with opportunity. The Commonwealth is competing and winning, the Commonwealth is stronger today than she has ever been. This is the state of the Commonwealth that I have had the immense honor of serving these past four years. Fortunately,

[07:49:55] this service journey has not been a solitary one. As I prepare to hand the key to the governor's mansion over to the governor-elect, Spamburger, I look around this room and I'm filled with gratitude. Filled with gratitude because I see so many men and women who have been involved in Virginia's incredible transformation. A transformation we have witnessed and we have led together. And so to the Lieutenant Governor, Winsome Earl Sears, and Attorney General,

[07:50:29] Jason Meares, to members of my cabinet and my administration, you have sacrificed so much. You've served with everything you have, and you've delivered for Virginians. Thank you.

[07:50:54] To our General Assembly partners, most times I've agreed with many of you. Sometimes I've disagreed with some of you. Frequently, you have been in my prayers, and always, always, I have considered you to be devoted public servants.

[07:51:15] Thank you for your partnership. The absolute best part of this season of service has been traveling every step of the way with the love of my life. She has brought grace and joy to the lives of so many Virginians.

[07:51:33] Thank you to our most extraordinary First Lady, Suzanne Youngkin. Finally, thank you to my fellow Virginians.

[07:52:11] to say thank you comes nowhere close to conveying the proud and profound sense of gratitude that I feel. Gratitude that this homegrown Virginian who was hired and given the chance to go to work for now more than 8.8 million Virginians. Now I do feel like I've met almost all 8.8 million of you from Loudoun County to Danville, from the Eastern Shore to Lee County and everywhere in between.

[07:52:43] I've met incredible Virginians, like the small business owner who courageously started his first shop and then expanded to two and then to three. Virginians like our teachers, who are exciting our

students about learning and helping them discover their passion in life.

[07:53:04] Like the nurse who is empowering a fellow Virginian to leave behind a life of addiction and start leading a life of hope. like the farmer who, rain or shine, makes sure the animals get fed and the fields get plowed, like the shipbuilders who arrive at the dock when it is dark each morning and who are building the

[07:53:27] most powerful navy in the world. Brave Virginians, like our law enforcement heroes who put on a bulletproof vest every day to go to work to keep us safe. Our amazing men and women who wear the cloth and serve our country. From the 150,000 active duty service members, to the reservist,

[07:54:01] to the great Virginia National Guard who has served Virginia since 1607. Remarkable Virginians, remarkable Virginians like the families of the fallen. No moments over these last four years have impacted me more than standing with families as we hear the end of watch and say goodbye to

[07:54:40] these quiet heroes. And to our newest Virginians who didn't grow up here but found opportunity here and now call Virginia home, all of you, all of you have deep, deep, deep impacts on our great commonwealth and therefore I say thank you. It is you who have been the driving force for all we've accomplished over these past four years. Thank you for believing that we could change the trajectory of a commonwealth that was stalled and make her soar.

[07:55:14] Thank you for showing that we can strengthen the spirit of Virginia together. Four years ago, Virginia was in a very different place. I was humbled recently when someone described what has taken place over these past four years as the great Virginia renaissance.

[07:55:32] A renaissance that reflected the real and widespread challenges that we faced. Our schools were 46 in the nation to reopen. Parents were being sidelined. students were falling behind. Virginia had the largest learning loss in the nation in fourth grade learning reading and math. 25,000 small businesses had closed their doors in 2021. Job recovery lagged behind nearly every other state. Violent crime had surged with a 20-year high in

[07:56:05] murder rate and for nine straight years more people moved away than moved to Virginia from the other 49 states. That was Virginia in January 2022, a Virginia that was lagging and not leading.

[07:56:21] But amid these challenges, we, all of us, saw Virginia with boundless potential just waiting to be unleashed. And so four years ago, collectively, we set out on a journey, a journey to unleash opportunity, to transform government, to make Virginia the very best place to live and work and raise a family. We could reduce tax burdens, lowering the cost of living for Virginians and generate record state revenue. We could restore educational excellence and see our

[07:56:55] students perform even better. We could enforce the laws and have the lowest recidivism rate in the nation. We could overhaul our behavioral health system and transform foster care so our kids are safe and families are strong. We could provide historic tax relief to our veterans and honor them and their families with award-winning care and support. We could lead the nation in connecting Virginians to high-speed broadband and invest record amounts in our roads and our bridges

[07:57:30] and our tunnels. We could transform the great city of Petersburg through a historic partnership and accelerate economic activity in Southwest. We could deliver hundreds of millions of dollars of procurement savings and serve all Virginians with best-in-class constituent services.

[07:57:50] We could protect free speech and keep our campuses safe. We said we would measure outcomes not in terms of activity but by actual results. And we also said there are some things about which there there can be no debate.

[07:58:08] That we must grow. And we could grow like never before. That we want Virginia to be a winning state with more jobs, more opportunity, more people. Not a losing state, shedding businesses and people. That we must make Virginia the place where companies want to build their future.

[07:58:26] Businesses like Lego and Eli Lilly, like AstraZeneca and Hitachi, and not impose anti-business policies that chase jobs and opportunity away. committed that we would stop doing what doesn't work and start doing more of what does work and what we know works is common sense and by putting common sense into action we've achieved the kind of transformation very few people thought was possible this transformation started with business investment and jobs and declaring on day one that virginia is open for business over and over again

[07:59:05] I heard the same refrain from Virginians, we want jobs, good paying jobs. But Virginia needed to start competing and Virginia needed to start winning. We worked together to build an economic development machine, a machine that is unleashing opportunity like never before. Virginia is now a leader in life sciences, a leader in advanced manufacturing, a leader powering some of the most critical industries and supply chains. Where made in America once again means made in Virginia.

[07:59:37] Where day after day, where day after day, Virginians from all walks of life are hearing those magical three words, you are hired.

[07:59:59] On day one, we went to work to build that dynamic economy. We streamlined regulations by 35%, saving Virginians $1.4 billion every year by cutting the cost of bureaucracy, including by reducing the average cost to build a home by $24,000.

[08:00:19] We invested a record amount in business-ready sites and drove Virginia government to move at the speed of business. We transformed workforce development, consolidating vast numbers of disparate programs into one new agency, Virginia Works, and created the nation's leading customized talent development program, the Virginia Talent Accelerator.

[08:00:44] We restructured the Virginia Economic Development Partnership, and most importantly, we competed. We competed to win, and win we have. We've won record business investment, over $157 billion, more than the last six administrations combined.

[08:01:04] Grown over 20,000 new high-growth startups, record investments that have fueled enormous job growth.

[08:01:34] Nearly 270,000 more Virginians are working today than when we started together. We have 255,000 open jobs, another 80,000 new jobs on the way from those investment commitments, along with 40,000 construction jobs.

[08:01:52] Virginia has jobs, lots of jobs. And Virginia is a winning state, and the winning continues. We announced in December, Avio's $500 million plant, which is expected to employ 1,500 people.

[08:02:08] And we finalized two more great manufacturing deals last fall, a $300 million plant that will employ over 1,000 people in Southside and a $1.2 billion facility that will employ nearly 300 people in Virginia's Piedmont region.

[08:02:25] We are leaving the next administration a robust pipeline of great projects that well exceeds $100 billion of capital investments and 32,000 jobs.

[08:03:02] Virginia has been on a tear because we have protected right to work. And so I ask you, please hear me. Please hear me.

[08:03:29] Change right to work and jobs will disappear. people will leave and they will take their tax dollars with them. Keeping Virginia soaring means keeping right to work right where it is. No amendments, no reforms, and no changes. Keeping Virginia on a winning streak also means

[08:04:08] continuing to work and cooperate with our federal partners and the Trump administration. Constructively working with the administration works for Virginians. When a governor picks up the phone and calls a cabinet secretary to work through issues, it's good for Virginia. Issues like turning on two and a half billion dollars of paused grants, attracting the Department of Housing and Urban Development headquarters with more than 2,700 jobs to Virginia, recruiting Fortune 50 businesses with billions of investment and thousands of jobs, and

[08:04:46] and delivering hurricane relief faster than any other state that is what is best for virginia the record jobs and investments we've attracted have driven record revenues 10 billion dollars in surplus revenue eight percent compounded revenue growth for four straight years 60 faster than the previous decade and record revenue that enabled nine billion dollars in tax relief and still

[08:05:22] historic investments across every critical area. And while throughout 2025, many predicted financial calamity, not only has financial calamity not happened, but once again, Virginia is running a

[08:05:39] significant surplus. Yesterday, we announced December revenue results, a 20% increase over

[08:06:10] last December and year-to-date growth of $1.2 billion after just six months. Revenues are growing at 8.6% again. No COVID money, no one-time gifts, just historic revenue growth driven by historic business growth, job growth, and strong consumer spending. My budget that I introduced included a re-forecast adding $1.2 billion in resources to fiscal year 2026 alone. December

[08:06:42] just added another $395 million to that number. Virginia has record resources. I included $700 million more tax relief in my proposed budget and huge investment increases in Medicaid, education, law enforcement, capital spending. And yet, bills raising nearly every tax known demand have been introduced. One thing we have clearly demonstrated is that lowering tax burdens brings

[08:07:15] people, it brings businesses, and it brings jobs. Increasing taxes drives them away. Just look at California and Illinois and New York and Maryland. Indeed, in 2023, for the first time in 10 years, more people moved to Virginia than moved away to the other 49 states. Common sense works.

[08:07:41] A significant part of that investment went to education, a record amount reflecting a $7 billion increase, 50% more since the pandemic. Empowering Virginians to seize unlimited opportunity all starts in the classroom. The pandemic wreaked havoc on Virginia students

[08:08:21] and families. Schools were closed too long unnecessarily. As I said, we were 46th in the nation to reopen our schools. The learning loss was devastating. Standards were lowered, parents were pushed out of their children's lives, and we risked losing an entire generation if we didn't act quickly. Restoring excellence in education has been our collective North Star. It started with putting parents back at the head of the table in their children's lives because, well, parents

[08:08:51] Matter. We, all of us, passed historic bipartisan legislation that allowed parents to choose if their child wore a mask and to allow parents to remove sexually explicit materials from their

[08:09:24] child's curriculum. We're exciting students again by gaining the real-world skills that they need to succeed after they graduate. We've launched 15 new lab schools with space for 5,000 students, and we already have a long waiting list. Innovative lab schools from the maritime trades outside of the shipyards in Hampton Roads, to space and aviation at Wallops Island, to data science and coding in the Shenandoah Valley and in Richmond, healthcare in Southwest, and teachers in the rural Piedmont

[08:09:58] region. And with our huge focus on career and technical education, four out of five Virginia high school students now graduate with a credential or a certificate. Great education outcomes require a great teacher and we've supported teachers. Teacher compensation is up nearly 20 percent. Teacher vacancies are down 36 percent and Virginia was just recently ranked the

[08:10:38] number one state in America to be a teacher. We also embrace transparency and accountability and raise standards to drive better student outcomes. Gone are the days of Virginia having the lowest proficiency base proficiency baseline in the country

[08:11:16] cheating our students by shuffling them along or worse lying about whether they could read or do math at grade level. We made our standardized tests harder and the students did better including a 20% surge in math proficiency. Of course students can't learn if they aren't in school in the first place. We locked arms together with the All in Virginia plan. And I'd like to thank Senators Locke and Lucas for your partnership. And now Virginia leads the nation in reducing chronic absenteeism and getting students

[08:11:50] back in the classroom. Intensive tutoring works. We've led all our peer states in math learning loss recovery. And the nationally leading Virginia Literacy Act is transforming the way students

[08:12:26] learn to read but in addition to learning loss we know that behavioral health distress among teens has been surging since even before the pandemic increased social media use and endless screen time are one of the main culprits these devices and apps are profiting off our kids and stealing their childhood but we collectively acted we collectively acted to reclaim childhood and create a healthier and happier Virginia. Bell to bell cell phone free education is now the law of

[08:12:57] the land across the Commonwealth of Virginia. My friends, Virginia is the model for the rest of the nation because in Virginia we don't follow, we lead. Academic performance is up, mental health

[08:13:33] and discipline challenges are down, after school cafeterias are humming loud with noise because students are talking to each other again and to all the parents who advocated for your children you have shown us once again that yes parents matter to make virginia the very best place to live and work and raise a family virginia has to be safe from day one of my administration we have backed the blue supporting encouraging and celebrating these heroic men and women we have

[08:14:10] collectively provided record funding we've invested in equipment and training increased salaries. I urge you, I urge you to keep investing, to keep supporting, and to keep backing the blue. We've taken on gangs, drugs, and human trafficking. Our statewide efforts include gang task forces, extensive collaboration and cooperation with other states, and with federal partners. We've seized enough fentanyl that otherwise could have killed every Virginian 10 times over. We've arrested violent gang members, including the number three leader of MS-13. We've brought down the most

[08:14:50] violent crimes, especially in the most violent cities, as part of Operation Ceasefire and Operation Bowl Blue Line. And thanks to our dedicated law enforcement professionals, we've seen a 30%

[08:15:03] decline in murders. On Monday, I had the honor of visiting the Virginia State Police's 144th class as they get ready to complete their basic session training.

[08:15:38] In a few weeks, this class will graduate 94 incredible men and women into the ranks of Virginia State Troopers, the second largest graduating class ever. Virginians are once again proud. They're proud and excited to enter this most noble profession.

[08:16:03] Thank you to our heroes who keep us safe, and thank you to Colonel Matt Hanley for your leadership. We tackled the scourge of drug addiction head-on.

[08:16:38] Our fight against fentanyl has been extraordinary. When we started this journey, fentanyl was claiming the lives of more than five Virginians a day. Suzanne and I have met, we have prayed, and we have cried with families who have buried a child, buried a spouse, a sister, a brother, a parent, because of this evil.

[08:17:02] And so we came together and launched a comprehensive fight against fentanyl. A fight where we've taken it to the front line by enhancing penalties and creating tougher new laws. Now drug dealers are on notice. If you push this poison and kill someone in the process, you will be held accountable and you will be charged with felony manslaughter.

[08:17:24] We've educated parents and students and teachers and coaches and pastors.

[08:17:52] Through the First Ladies, it only takes one statewide campaign. and the Attorney General's One Pill Can Kill Public Awareness Initiative. We've equipped Virginians to stop an overdose in progress by delivering 400,000 life-saving naloxone doses and trained nearly 100,000 people to use them, including our members of the General Assembly.

[08:18:25] We locked arms with community partners, including our it's only take one college ambassadors and heroic fentanyl family ambassadors whose courage inspires us all every single day. Thanks to our comprehensive efforts, Virginia now leads the nation in reducing fatal fentanyl overdoses by 59%.

[08:19:08] Our fight isn't over, but once where there was heartbreak, now there is hope. Empowering Virginians to lead the lives that God intended has been the driving force behind our complete overhaul of our behavioral health system.

[08:19:24] Virginians in crisis needed help and could not get it. So four years ago, we started a journey to transform behavioral health, to expand capacity across the state, to deliver faster, more effective response, to get law enforcement out of the emergency room and back on the street, to expand the workforce.

[08:19:43] Today, we've increased our care capacity in beds and chairs by 241%. We've improved our responsiveness with 988 crisis calls by 456% to over 30,000 calls per month.

[08:20:00] We've deployed nearly three times as many mobile crisis teams across the Commonwealth, achieving a statewide average response time of just 42 minutes. And we've substantially grown the workforce, adding over 30,000 new healthcare workers.

[08:20:18] The Commonwealth is setting the national standard for how to care for individuals in crisis, to get them the right help right now.

[08:20:48] When Virginians need help, Virginians show up. There has been no better example of neighbor helping neighbor than when Hurricane Helene tore through Southwest Virginia. In the face of devastating loss, the true character of our commonwealth shone through heroic rescues by law enforcement, first responders, and our Virginia National Guard.

[08:21:11] Volunteers and donations rebuilt or repaired over 110 homes and assisted over 4,000 households. Collaboration with state, local, and federal resources has led to rebuilding Route 58 faster, delivering farm recovery grants before any other state, accelerating the restructuring of the creeper trail at lightning pace so this huge economic contributor

[08:21:39] can be reopened by November of this year.

[08:22:02] And the support coming from Virginia's $50 million recovery fund is now flowing. I visited Southwest Virginia 30 times in the 15 months following Helene. And I can tell you that today, Southwest Virginia has their collective foot on the accelerator.

[08:22:20] They're not turning back. And all of us should make sure they soar with the rest of the Commonwealth. The corner of the Commonwealth is benefiting from tremendous job growth and business investment.

[08:22:52] And because business is booming and our population is growing, it means our energy and power needs are rising as well. For too long, Virginia's policies and the utilities planned for a stagnant Virginia. Well, we are not stagnant. We are growing.

[08:23:10] And we must execute a plan where power is reliable, affordable, and made in Virginia. Meeting this growing power need means continuing to support an all-of-the-above power plan.

[08:23:25] what it definitely doesn't mean is rejoining reggie and i know we debate this and i know some

[08:24:07] of us disagree but it's a bad deal it doesn't work it's a regressive tax that drives up the cost of living for all virginians it also doesn't mean driving away data centers the positive economic contribution from data centers is enormous the industry will pay their fair share of power costs, even bringing their own power behind the meter. The national security imperative will drive huge investment and lots of jobs, and Virginia should win. Don't drive it away to the

[08:24:42] other states. What it does mean is that we must continue to build. We must build gas power generation. We must build nuclear power. We need to double our generating capacity in the next 10 years and renewables alone which by themselves will drive up costs and risk brownouts just can't get it done just look at maryland where electricity rates have nearly doubled and are 19 higher than the national average i urge you to undo vasia it simply does not work for virginians the good news

[08:25:20] is that we can both meet our energy and power needs and be great stewards of god's natural resource blessings to Virginia. With the huge efforts we have made to support our Chesapeake Bay 2025 goals, including record funding for agricultural best management practices, I am proud to report that the Chesapeake Bay is healthier than it has been in decades.

[08:25:52] Virginia led the way to set the new framework signed in December for the next phase of preserving our great chesapeake bay watershed virginia's transformation has been broad from healthy

rivers

[08:26:28] and streams to healthy moms and healthy babies through our healthy moms healthy families and healthy communities initiative we have seen a 68 reduction in maternal mortality blocks for

[08:27:03] virginia families delivered the best public private parent choice model for early education and child care in America. Not only maintaining full access for 74,000 children after the Biden administration cut funding, but also with my recent budget introduction providing 6,000 more slots. 6,000 more slots in our quality model that is leading the nation. We've shown it is possible to make government work for Virginians. The Virginia Employment Commission has cleared all

[08:27:37] its backlog of more than 700,000 work items coming out of COVID, and we've cleared 1.7 million in total. Among our peer states, we now make benefit decisions faster than anyone, and we rank top third at getting out the first payment to unemployed Virginians. We've cut waiting times at DMV from nearly 40 minutes to, in October, the shortest average wait in history, 5.9 minutes.

[08:28:08] my friends we've shown that with clear purpose and common sense it is indeed possible to make government work for virginians it's possible to take a commonwealth that was stalled and make her soar like never before by every single metric today virginia is stronger than she has ever been

[08:28:45] stronger financially stronger educationally stronger environmentally stronger in terms of public safety stronger in terms of behavioral health with better infrastructure and with more opportunity than ever before. We have strengthened the spirit of Virginia together, a spirit of courage and fortitude, of compassion and love, of resiliency in the face of challenge and always rising to meet the new ones. And this same spirit was beating in the hearts of our forebearers 250 years ago. Throughout this year, all of America will take part in our semi-quincentennial

[08:29:24] celebrations. But no state has as much to celebrate as we do here in Virginia. 150 years ago, it was Virginians who led the way to America's founding. Washington, Jefferson, Madison, Monroe, Patrick

[08:30:00] Henry. Mr. Henry, I will miss working in your building every day. And so many others along the way. America was made in Virginia. This new nation conceived in liberty was born and then built on

[08:30:36] those foundational values that have sustained us for two and a half century, even when we did not live up to them. The revolutionary belief that government is of the people, that government exists to serve the people, not for people to serve the government. Because our rights, those unalienable rights of life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness come from God, not from

[08:31:02] government. The foundational pillars and values that must always define America were born right here in Virginia. Pillars and values that have made America a beacon of hope to the world for 250 years. And those values and that beacon must continue to guide Virginia's future as well. 250

[08:31:42] years ago, Virginia led. And I will humbly submit that over these past four years, Virginia has led in so many ways that may have stunned others, but should surprise none of us. And so as we prepare to write the next 250 year chapter of our nation's history. Virginia should and Virginia must continue to lead. It has been the honor of a lifetime for Suzanne and me to serve in this season alongside

[08:32:18] all of you. So from the bottom of our incredibly grateful hearts, thank you Virginia. May God bless all of you. May he bless the great Commonwealth of Virginia and may he always bless the United

[08:32:33] States of America. Thank you. Senator Cypress, as many favor the motion will say aye. Those

[08:34:48] opposed will say no. The motion is agreed to. The Senate from Loughton, Senator Sreena Vassan. As many favor the motion will say aye. Those opposed will say no. The motion is agreed to.

[08:35:06] The Joint Assembly Senate Chamber. Live Senate video is now available at youtube.com slash

[08:41:37] at Senate of Virginia. Virginia. Richmond, Virginia. Chamber.

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